influence on the government and both Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee and I share a historical bonding with it'.[3] On the other hand, some senior RSS leaders, in speeches from the same platform, publicly expressed their dissatisfaction with the political class and listed their key concerns. Although the RSS chief later denied that this meant that there were differences between the Vajpayee government and the Sangh,[4] the open criticism was a reflection of the growing tension between the two at the time. As I followed BJP leaders around the camp, I was struck by the genuine deference they showed to senior RSS leaders like Rajendra Singh (Rajju Bhaiyya), who had stepped down as RSS chief earlier that year due to poor health. After hanging out with RSS volunteers in their khakhi-white-black uniforms for three days, I headlined my TV report from Mahabalipuram, 'Show of Strength by RSS'.[5]

In retrospect, I was only half-right. The political message to the government was indeed one of strength, showcased in the leaders' speeches and through synchronised martial displays by hundreds of lathi-carrying RSS volunteers in full view of the invited cameras. Despite having a BJP-led government in power, the RSS was grappling with a serious crisis of growth that year. Its leaders at the camp were deeply worried about the decline in new membership numbers and the reluctance of young Indians to join up.

Mohan Bhagwat, then RSS sarkaryavah (general secretary) and later appointed sarsanghchalak (chief) in 2009[6], blamed the rising popularity of satellite TV for falling recruitment. As he lamented to a visiting reporter in Agra, 'Children don't know their mother tongue. They don't call their father Pitaji but Daddy and Papa. They watch too much TV.' He was right. A young RSS volunteer, fourteen-year-old Navin Sagar from the RSS-affiliated Saraswati Shishu Mandir in Agra, aptly summed up the organisation's crisis to the same reporter: 'I watch TV. Cartoon Network and "Aahat" are my favourites. I learn computers and want to go to the US. What they teach in the RSS is good but irrelevant.'[7]

The growth of television and its impact on membership had long been a worry for RSS leaders, who had started devising countermeasures. Seshadri Chari, then editor of the RSS magazine